

CHAPTER

3

The Sikh Genocide of November 1984 - Delhi and Beyond

"I realized what Jews must have felt like in Nazi Germany. The killing assumed the proportion of a genocide of the Sikh community. For the first time I understood what words like pogrom, holocaust and genocide really meant. Sikh houses and shops were marked for destruction in much the same way as those of Jews in Tsarist Russia or Nazi Germany."

—Khushwant Singh, former member of
the Indian Parliament and journalist

On 31 October 1984, the Indian Prime Minister, Mrs. Gandhi witnessed the hands of justice from her two Sikh bodyguards. What followed begged belief. Thousands of Sikhs were massacred in barbaric burnings, beatings, and subjected to rape. Encouraged by central government ministers and Members of Parliament with the connivance of the police and media, mobs were assembled to carry out a three day orgy of murders and plunder.

Early the next morning, hordes of people from the suburbs of Delhi were transported on government buses to various localities in the city where the Sikh population was concentrated. The mobilization was possible due to the state's resources. The

criminal hordes descending on the city carrying iron rods, knives, clubs and combustible material, including kerosene, for arson. They were also supplied with government-issued voter lists of houses and business establishments belonging to Sikhs in various localities. Government leaders and politicians led the crowds and directed their destruction.

The Indian government controlled television station Doordarshan and All India Radio began broadcasting provocative slogans seeking bloody vengeance, “khooṁ ka badla khooṁ se lenge” (we will take blood for blood!). This was the code to launch the attack.

Murderous gangs of about 200 people led by government leaders, with some police participating, began to swarm into Sikh houses, hacking the occupants to pieces, chopping off the heads of children, raping women, tying Sikh men to tires set aflame with kerosene, and burning down the houses and shops after ransacking them. Mobs stopped buses and trains in and out of Delhi pulling out Sikh passengers to be lynched to death or doused with kerosene and burnt alive.

In some areas, the Sikh families grouped together for self-defence. The police officials then arrived to disperse them, by force when persuasion did not work. In other areas, the police searched the houses for weapons including Kirpans, and confiscated them before the mobs came.

The Sikh Genocide in Delhi has been documented by several organisations. The People's Union for Civil Liberties and the People's Union of Democratic Rights published a joint report, called “Who are the Guilty?” The report said that “the attacks on the members of the Sikh community in Delhi... far from being spontaneous expressions of “madness” and of “grief and anger” at Mrs. Gandhi's assassination, as made out by the authorities, were the outcome of a well-organized plan marked by acts of both deliberate commission and omission by important politicians of the Congress and by authorities in the administration....” The report mentions the names of 16 important Congress politicians, 13 police officers and 198 others, accused by survivors and eye-witnesses (Kothari and Mukhtoy).

The report by the Citizens for Democracy concluded that the “carnage was orchestrated by the ruling party” (Rao, Ghose, and Pancholi). Yet another investigative report compiled by a team of prominent citizens including retired Chief Justice of the Supreme Court, S. M. Sikri, former civil servants Badruddin Tyabji, Rajeshwar Dayal and others, came to the same conclusions (Sikri, Tyabji, Dayal, Narain, Srinivasvaradan).

Gurdwaras Attacked

Guru Tegh Bahadur, the 9th Sikh Guru, was executed in Delhi on the orders of the then Mughal emperor, Aurangzeb in 1675. It was a sacrifice without parallel in the history of religious persecution. Here was a man killed for defending the religious freedom of people of another religion, especially a tradition he adamantly opposed. The Hindu Pandits of Kashmir were being forcibly converted into Islam, and the Sikh Guru decided to defend their freedom of worship. The spot where his body was cremated is today marked by Gurdwara Rakab Ganj in Delhi.

This sacrifice was however lost on the mob attacking the Gurdwara on November 1, 1984. Two Sikhs lost their lives, and many attempts were made to burn the Gurdwara. Senior Delhi police chiefs and a Congress MP, Kamal Nath, were also present during the siege. Hundreds of Gurdwaras were attacked and burnt across northern India, in a similar pattern to that of Jewish synagogues during Kristallnacht 1938. Copies of the Sikh scriptures, Guru Granth Sahib, were publicly burned.

According to historian Rajni Kothari, “Evidence from various sources is mounting that soon after Operation Bluestar and the extremist response thereto in parts of Punjab, a plan of retaliation by identifying Sikh targets ranging from households to commercial establishments to Gurdwaras had been undertaken including the planning of logistics and the techniques to be employed” (Kothari, 14).

Mobs were armed with iron rods of a uniform size. Madhu Kishwar, editor of women’s magazine, *Manushi*, saw some of the rods being distributed among the miscreants. Mobs also had

an abundant supply of petrol and kerosene. Victims traced the source of kerosene to dealers belonging to the Congress Party. For instance, a Congress worker named Brahmanand Gupta, a kerosene dealer, figures prominently in affidavits filed from Sultanpuri (Kishwar).

Sequence of Events

October 31, 1984

9:20am: Indira Gandhi was shot by two of her security guards at her residence No. 1, Safdarjung Road, New Delhi and rushed to the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS).

11am: Announcement on All India Radio specifying that the guards who shot Indira Gandhi were Sikhs. A large crowd gathered near AIIMS.

4pm: Rajiv Gandhi returned from West Bengal and reached AIIMS. Stray incidents of attacks on Sikhs in and around that area occur.

5:30pm: The cavalcade of President Zail Singh was stoned as it approached AIIMS.

Late evening and night: Mobs fanned out in different directions from AIIMS. The violence against Sikhs spread, starting in the neighbouring constituency of Congress councillor Arjun Dass. The violence included the burning of vehicles and other properties of Sikhs.

Shortly after Rajiv Gandhi was sworn in as Prime Minister, senior advocate and Opposition leader Ram Jethmalani met Home Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao and urged him to act fast and save Sikhs from further attacks. Despite all these developments, no measures were taken to control the violence or prevent further attacks on Sikhs throughout the night between October 31 and November 1.

November 1, 1984

Several Indian government leaders held meetings on the night of October 31 and morning of November 1, mobilizing their followers to attack Sikhs on a mass scale. The first killing of a Sikh was reported from east Delhi in the early hours of November 1. By about 9am, armed mobs, escorted by the police, took over the streets of Delhi and launched a full scale genocide.

Violence Spreads Throughout India

The meticulousness with which the massacres were organised bespeaks a definite plan, being repeatedly executed in Saket, Bhogal, Jangpura, and Ashram in South Delhi before spreading to the trans-Jamuna colonies, the resettlement colonies in West Delhi, and other areas in the northern parts of the city. The pattern of killing was replicated in areas like Sultanpuri and Mangolpuri. First the police sealed off the areas, then Indian government employees and leaders led mobs, armed with voters lists, began their purge. One family alone in Palam Village has 21 widows.

The violence wasn't just confined to Delhi, but unleashed throughout India. Sikhs were killed in Uttar Pradesh, mostly in cities like Kanpur, where the administration there let things take their course for a day or so before imposing curfew. The steel town of Bokaro bore the brunt of the violence in Bihar. In Madhya Pradesh, the violence was spread over nearly 40 towns including Indore, Bhopal, Jabalpur, Ujjain, Raipur, Gwalior, Raigarh, Mahendergarh and Bina. Similar attacks of violence occurred in Haryana, West Bengal, Himachal Pradesh, Assam, Maharashtra, Rajasthan and Gujarat. In fact, as recently as 2011, two mass grave sites in Haryana, at Hondh Chillar and Pataudi (near Gurgaon) were discovered. They most likely only represents the tip of the iceberg as few have attempted to document the murders outside of Delhi.

Massacre in East Delhi

Rahul Kuldip Bedi and Joseph Maliakan of the *Indian Express* were the first newspaper reporters to enter Trilokpuri, in East Delhi on 2 November. This is what they reported:

Shortly after sunset on 1 November, the mob, busy in Block 32, Trilokpuri, East Delhi, dispersed for dinner. It had built up an appetite. Killing, burning and pillaging the 400-odd Sikh families in the block had, indeed left them hungry. An hour later, their bellies full, they casually strolled back, to the two narrow lanes in the trans-Jamuna resettlement colony, forcibly plunged into darkness; to join those already hard at work.

Labouring at a leisurely pace they split open Lachman Singh's skull and pouring kerosene into the gash set alight the half-alive man in front of Gyan Devi, his wife. Balwant Singh, who tried to escape after shaving himself, had his eyes gouged out before he too was similarly burnt. Sarb Singh, his terror-stricken father-in-law, watched. The sport continued, interspersed with solicitous visits from the local police to ensure that things were going well.

The calculated carnage in Delhi and over 80 towns in the country had begun. The pattern was similar all over, the brutality unbelievable and barbaric, the tragedy unspeakable. On November 1, all exit points from Trilokpuri have been sealed off by massive concrete pipes. Conscientious men from the colony, armed with lathis, guarded the pipes, barely a kilometre from two police stations – Patparganj and Kalyanpuri – to ensure that no Sikh escapes. Also, that no one except the police set foot into Trilokpuri.

Around 2 o'clock on 2 November, we enter Trilokpuri. Just about the time that the killers, having toiled for 30 long and uninterrupted hours, were scouring Block 32 for booty or any young Sikh that inadvertently, they may, have overlooked, as if around 350 Sikhs already killed and an equal number of looted and burnt houses was not enough. A plume of smoke spirals upwards from half-charred bodies. Two lanes of Block 32, an area of around 500 square yards inhabited by around 450 Sikh families, is littered with corpses, the drains choked with dismembered limbs and masses of

hair. Cindered human remains lie scattered in the first 20 yards of the first lane. The remaining 40-yard stretch of the street is strewn with naked bodies, brutally hacked beyond recognition. Lifeless arms hang over balconies; many houses have bodies piled three-deep on their doorsteps (Bedi, 51). The massacre in Trilokpuri has become the largest ever massacre in a single residential block in any city in post-Independence India.

Refugee Camps Closed

On 10 November, the government – anxious to proclaim that “normalcy has been restored” – with unimaginable callousness started to forcibly close the refugee camps, to send the refugees back to the colonies from which they had fled. These were the same places where they had seen their relatives being hacked and burnt just a week earlier, and where their houses were nothing now but burnt-out empty shells. They were the same places in which the very politicians, gundas and policemen they had seen loot, burn and kill roamed freely. Their heart-rending pleas that they should not be thrown back to the mercies of these persons, that they should not be sent back till their colonies had been made secure, till their houses had been made habitable proved of no avail. They were given 50 rupees (less than \$1) apiece plus some dry rations and herded into buses. When, on their return, they huddled together in a park, as in Sultanpuri, they were forcibly dispersed (Shourie, 85)

Systematic Rape

Although rape had become widespread in the days of the massacres, it received little coverage. This may have been due to the social stigma associated with it, and partly because the killings were so intense in some neighbourhoods that it overshadowed rape. In Trilokpuri, East Delhi, after the massacres had taken their full toll and no Sikh man was left alive, about thirty Sikh women were abducted and held captive in the nearby village of Chilla. Countless cases of systematic rape occurred, but none figured in the official inquiries. H.S. Phoolka and Manoj Mitta have argued

that this neatly fitted in with the government view of an “emotional reaction” to Mrs. Gandhi’s assassination. Rajiv Gandhi had already stated this in his “When a Big Tree Falls, the Earth Shakes” speech, which callously excused the government-led murderers and rapists committing heinous acts. Far from being spontaneous, as many of the affidavits from the victims show, there were little signs of grief or emotion over the assassination among the rampaging mobs (Mitta and Phoolka, 68). There was, however, a definitive pattern to “cause serious bodily and mental harm” to Sikh women, as defined in Article Two of the United Nations’ Genocide Convention.

On November 1, Gurdip Kaur, her three sons and her husband were at home. Here is how she described the attack.

Three of the men ran out and were set on fire. My youngest son stayed in the house with me. But they came into the house. Those young boys, 14 and 16 year olds, began to drag my son out even though he was hiding behind me. They tore my clothes and stripped me naked in front of my son. They raped me right there, in front of my son, in my own house. They were young boys, maybe eight of them.

After they had taken my honour, they left. I took my son to sit among the women but they came and dragged him away. They took him to the street corner, hit him with lathis, sprinkled kerosene over him, and burnt him alive. I tried to save him but they struck me with knives and broke my arm. At that time I was completely naked. I had managed to get a hold of an old sheet, which I had wrapped around myself. If I had even one piece of clothing on my body, I would have gone and thrown myself over my son and tried to save him. I would have done anything to save at least one young man of my family. Not one of the four is left” (Kishwar).

A woman from Trilokpuri described her harrowing experience. She and her husband, originally from Sind, had migrated to Rajasthan in 1947. Later, they moved to Delhi in search of better prospects. During the slum clearance drive of 1974-75, they had been resettled in Trilokpuri.

She, her husband, and three of their children survive, but the eldest son aged 18 was killed on November 1. She described the mob led by the Congress block pradhan (president) as consisting of some people from the same block and others from neighbouring blocks and nearby villages. While the block pradhan identified Sikh houses and urged the mobs to loot, burn and kill, the women were herded together into one room. Some of them ran away, but were pursued to the nearby nallah where they were raped. Their shrieks and cries for help fell on deaf ears. From among the women held in the room, the hoodlums asked each other to select whosoever they chose. All the women were stripped and many were raped. She herself was raped by ten men. Their lust satisfied, they told the women to get out, naked as they were. For fear of their lives they did so, hiding their pain as best as possible. Each begged for or borrowed a garment from relenting neighbours and sought shelter wherever they could.

This widow, a former resident of Kartarnagar (trans-Yamuna area), related that their house was looted and burnt by a mob on November 2. Her husband and two sons, one married only four months before, were dragged out of the house and mercilessly beaten. Thereafter, kerosene was poured over the three men and they were set alight. No police or army was in evidence at the time. She could, she said, identify the person who killed her husband, though she did not know his name. She was definite about the name of his father: a weaver of the area. She had originally come from Rawalpindi at the time of Partition. This was her second nightmarish experience of mob fury during which she had lost everything, including three male members of her family. She was accompanied by a completely dazed girl, barely an adult, widow of her recently-married and recently-butchered son. This young girl sat through her mother-in-law's harrowing testimony shedding silent tears of grief and despair.

Indian Government Leaders Meet to Finalize Genocide

One police officer, who was in charge of Kalyanpuri police station in the East Delhi Trilokpuri area worst affected by the carnage,

subsequently broke ranks to the lawyer, H.S. Phoolka. Shoorveer Singh Tyagi was himself implicated in the violence and had been suspended, but he declared that he had been made a scapegoat. In a sensational disclosure, he stated the massacres were a result of a conspiracy hatched on the evening of October 31 in the house of senior Congress leader, H.K.L. Bhagat. According to Tyagi, it was a secret meeting attended by senior police officers from East Delhi. Instructions were to be given to officers down the line to let the killings take place and then erase all traces of the crime. Many areas were successful in doing this, but Trilokpuri, due to the sheer scale of the killings and the amount of bodies, was still littered with bodies when journalists arrived. Hence Tyagi was handed a suspension by the Deputy Commissioner of Police, Hukam Chand Jatav.

Ajay Kaur, one of the victims, made an allegation in her affidavit that she had seen Congress leader H.K.L. Bhagat telling a crowd in her neighbourhood that the police would “not interfere for three days,” and those people were therefore at liberty to “kill every Sikh” and do their “duty to Bharat Mata (mother India)” (Mitta and Phoolka, 77).

Former governor and defence secretary, Govind Narain, states “Definitely there was a lot of evidence before us in trans Yamuna area where people had told us that Shri H.K.L. Bhagat, a Congress leader, had planned an organised massacre there. There was evidence before us that in other areas the people who were instigating and organising with petrol tins or kerosene tins to set houses on fire and here the names of Sajjan Kumar and Shri Jagdish Tytler were mentioned. Some of these names also figure in the various affidavits that were filed before us” (Mitta and Phoolka, 221).

According to Jagjit Singh’s affidavit, “Congress (I) leader, Sajjan Kumar ordered distribution of iron rods from the truck parked nearby there. After this distribution of iron rods, Sajjan Kumar told the mob to attack Sikhs and kill them, loot their properties and then burn their houses and shops” (Affidavit of Jagjit Singh, Mishra Commission).

Raj Kumar of Palam Colony witnessed a huge meeting in Mangalpuri addressed by Sajjan Kumar. The mob raised slogans such as “kill the Sardars (Sikhs).” Moti Singh of Sultanpuri witnessed another meeting, this time in Sultanpuri, where Sajjan Kumar extolled people to kill the Sikhs and collect Rs 1000 for each Sikh killed. The police were also in attendance (Affidavit of Raj Kumar, Mishra Commission).

Congress party leaders, who owned oil depots, provided the crucial access to abundant amounts of kerosene, a resource too expensive for most of the assailants to afford.

Cynthia Keppley-Mahmood, an Associate Professor at the University of Notre Dame, was told by a Sikh woman, who had three close family members in high positions in the government, that she was requested to take her children out of school and get them to a safe place well before the killing began. She suspected that a plan to create communal violence had already been planned to coincide with the birthday of Guru Nanak in the second week of November, but had been pushed forward to take advantage of the conditions created by Mrs. Gandhi's assassination (Keppley Mahmood, 139).

Delhi Police

Far from helping Sikhs faced with mob violence, the Delhi police spent the first day disarming Sikhs of any weapons with which they could defend themselves. On the morning of November 1, mobs led by local Congress leader, Dr. Ashok Gupta, descended on Block 11 of Kalyanpuri. The Sikhs of the area greeted the mobs with gunfire, forcing the group to retreat. Within minutes though, the police arrived. Flanked by armed constables, the chief of Kalyanpuri police station, Shoorveer Singh Tyagi, read out a list of licensed weapon holders. On the pretext of defusing tension, Tyagi ordered all the Sikhs listed to surrender their weapons, insisting the police would protect them. Those who refused were threatened at gunpoint. 25 of the Sikhs were also arrested and sent to Tihar jail to be detained. These arrests were the only ones to figure in the police records of arrests on the first day of the massacre. After

seizing licensed weapons in this manner, the police left the Sikhs of Block 11 at the mercy of the mobs waiting outside.

None of the police officers of Kalyanpuri, which covered Trilokpuri, were ever brought to book, despite evidence from victims and journalists that they had a hand in the killing. Shoorveer Singh Tyagi, Station House Officer, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Sewa Dass, and Hukam Chand Jatav went on to get their promotions more than once in their careers. Sewa Dass went on to become Special Commissioner of Delhi Police.

The mobs were paid in proportion to the number of Sikhs they killed. Joginder Kaur, a survivor, had a very telling conversation with one of the police inspectors at Palam Colony, who had taken pity on her, as “[mobs] were otherwise apprehending and killing sadars (Sikhs).” A mob they had come across pleaded with the police officers to hand over Joginder Kaur’s two sons or else they would be “putting them to a loss of 500 rupees each” (Mitta and Phoolka, 77).

Jugti Ram was one of the few police officers to have rescued Sikh women who had been abducted and held at a nearby village, and also sent a message to his superiors about the massacres. It took 20 years for this crucial evidence to emerge. As duty officer in Kalyanpuri police station, he had sent a wireless message to Sewa Dass, Deputy Commissioner of Police, informing him about the large-scale killings in Block 32 in Trilokpuri and recorded the same in his logbook. He was subsequently moved from his post and into the field as his message was in defiance of the order not to record any messages relating to the killings of Sikhs.

30-Year Cover-up

The Indian government quickly described the massacres of November 1984 as a “communal riot.” This not only mischaracterized the violence, but also masked its most brutal dimensions. It also paints the events as disorganised violence as genuine riots often are. But as we have seen, the Sikh Genocide of November 1984 was far from disorganised. There is no doubt that the government had an intent to destroy in part the Sikhs from particular locales in Delhi and

throughout India. Government officials were involved in conspiracy, incitement, attempt and complicity to crimes of genocide.

Sikhs were targeted for extermination in localized areas as the following evidence shows: slogans calling for the death of Sikhs, repeated attacks by death squads whose whole purpose was to kill all Sikhs they could find, direct attacks and looting of Sikh property, destruction of symbols and places of worship. Police participation in the massacres was heavy, as was the manipulation of evidence, and the intimidation of victims' families after the violence. The most damning evidence against the idea of a "riot" is the way it was systematically organised by private meetings of government officials the night before the plan was put into action, organised dissemination of rumours, effective identification of Sikhs through voter and ration lists, organised transportation of the gangs, large-scale provision and distribution of weapons and kerosene, and finally the systematic uniformity in the method of killing.

In 2001, the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia ruled that the killing of an estimated 8,000 Bosnian Muslims in Srebrenica in July 1995 constituted genocide. The International Crisis Group, looking at violations in Kosovo, stated that "those who seek to deny that genocide has occurred on the basis of a body count do the term an injustice. It is clear from the very words of the definition in the Convention that more than killing is envisaged. The target of the crime is the group and the destruction of the group, or part of it, is the objective."

Genocide is defined as "any of the following acts committed with the intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnical, racial or religious group - Killing members of the group; Causing serious bodily or mental harm to members of the group; Deliberately inflicting on the group conditions of life calculated to bring about its physical destruction in whole or in part." While the "intentionalist" school of genocide scholars may point to the lack of a "smoking gun" document, the "instrumentalists" can see the pieces holistically and see the contours that point towards a genocide committed against the Sikhs.

Endless and Useless Inquiries

Misra Inquiry (1985)

This inquiry itself turned out to be a part of the cover-up. The Supreme Court judge who conducted the inquiry, Ranganath Misra, subsequently joined the Congress party and became a member of the Rajya Sabha on its ticket. Misra's pre-determination to exonerate the Congress party and its leaders was so obvious that a panel of eminent persons of the Citizens Justice Committee, which was the main representative of the victims, walked out half-way through his inquiry.

Dubious government-sponsored agencies that were clearly anti-victim were allowed to gain access to the Inquiry, to the point that they were able to intimidate the victims just before their deposition. A blanket ban on press coverage was instituted to prevent the press from getting any wind of the mechanics of a cover-up.

Advocate Harvinder Singh Phoolka, who tirelessly fought for the victims as part of the Citizens Justice Committee, points the finger at judges as part of the cover-up.

Nanavati Inquiry (2005)

The Nanavati Commission of 2005 indicted the politicians for the massacre in Trilokpuri, but stated that "it appears that Shri (H.K.L.) Bhagat, Rampal Saroj and Dr. Ashok, who were local Congress leaders, had taken active part in the anti-Sikh riots in this area. But since they had all been acquitted in the criminal cases filed against them, the Commission does not recommend any further action against them."

The Inquiry had found that a "large number of affidavits indicate that local Congress (I) leaders and workers had either incited or helped the mobs in attacking the Sikhs," and went on to say that "but for the backing and help of influential and resourceful persons, killing of Sikhs so swiftly and in large numbers could not have happened." It then went out of its way to give clearance to the

top leaders, including Rajiv Gandhi, and home minister Narasimha Rao, who clearly had not exercised their powers to stop the violence. Other high ranking Congress leaders who had a hand in the killing were also exonerated due to a “lack of evidence.” Furthermore, all the police officials in the affected areas of East and West Delhi were acquitted.

Every few years, especially when the BJP and other parties that oppose the Congress Party come to power, they call for new inquiries. As of 2014, over 10 commissions and committees had been instituted. While in Delhi, there has been extensive documentation of the genocide and leaders of the massacre have largely been identified. No justice has been given to the victims. Recommendations of the inquiries are not enacted; perpetrators of the genocide are rewarded with cabinet positions and other important posts; the families and victims continue to languish. Only those that delivered justice are celebrated.

1984 and the Indian Media

As soon as it became clear Mrs. Gandhi's assassins were two Sikhs, the government-controlled television station, Doordarshan, and the All India Radio, began broadcasting scenes from Teen Murti House, where Mrs. Gandhi's body lay in state, with mourners shouting provocative slogans seeking bloody vengeance. “Khoon ka badla khoon se lenge” (we will take blood for blood!), they declared. Aseem Shrivastava, an independent reporter, noted this happened time after time “within earshot of the new Prime Minister, Rajiv Gandhi.” He further added “such seemed to have been the depth of state endorsement of the violence, that not one image of the looting and arsoning, let alone of the killing, was ever shown on TV. It would have appeared that the city of 9 or 10 million people was in solemn sorrow and mourning at the death of the great departed leader.” The administration quickly imposed strict censorship of both national and international press regarding reporting of the violence. Satellite transmission facilities some U.S. journalists were using to send images out of India were damaged. All journalists were banned from entering relief camps, and copies

of the magazine, *Surya*, which had a picture of bodies burning, were removed from news stands. In the state of Punjab, all newspapers were banned from reporting on the carnage and throughout India, government-run television and radio stations also carried no news of the genocide.

In contrast, during the December 1984 parliamentary elections, huge posters went up around India showing Sikhs brandishing automatic weapons over a bullet-ridden body of the former Prime Minister and asking voters to unite against this menace.

In 1987, the Bombay-born author, Salman Rushdie, while visiting some of the surviving widows, was refused permission to use his camera. Such was the paranoia and conspiracy of the government. He ended up just using their voices to record testimonies for his documentary, "The Riddle of Midnight."

If one was to go into any book shop in New Delhi to find a book on the events of 1984, they would have struggled. When the People's Union for Democratic Rights (PUDR) and the People's Union for Civil Liberties (PUCL) released their report on the massacres in their report, "Who are the Guilty?" it was swiftly banned by the government in 1985. *Government Organised Carnage* (Sarkari Katal-i-am), by eyewitness Gurcharan Singh Babbar, was also banned in 1998.

When an independent report about the events in the Punjab, "Report to the Nation: Oppression in Punjab by the Citizens for Democracy" was released, the government arrested the owner of the press, Om Prakash Gupta, and general secretary, N.D. Pancholi. They were charged with sedition and inciting sectarian discord. President of the Citizens for Democracy, and retired Supreme Court Justice, V.M. Tarkunde was also charged with sedition.

When Associate Press reporter, Brahma Chellaney reported in *The Times (UK)* that soldiers in the Golden Temple "tied Sikhs up and shot them at point blank range" during the June army attack, the government charged him with sedition. He was accused of "arousing the religious emotions" of Sikhs who may have read *The Times* in the UK.

The mass entertainment industry in Bollywood remained silent for a long period after 1984. Both the Kapoor and Bachchan families,

who dominated the film industry, were close to Rajiv Gandhi and the Congress party. In fact, many noticed Amitabh Bachchan leading the chants for revenge and murder of Sikhs at Indira Gandhi's funeral. It would not be until 2005 that an Indian director living in the U.S., Shonali Bose, would make a highly acclaimed film set against the events of 1984. *Amu* was released in 2005 in India and tried to deal with India's collective amnesia about the events of November 1984. The Indian Censor Board delayed the film's release for 3 months. Finally in December 2004 the verdict was given after actor Anupam Kher was fired for initially passing *Amu*. Six lines of dialog were ordered to be removed from the film – or redubbed with acceptable dialogue. Almost all the lines were from the scene where a group of widows explain to the protagonists who exactly organised the “riots” :“Minister hee to thhe. Unhee ke shaye pe sab hua” (It was a Minister. It was all done at his direction). Saare shamil thhe... police, afsar, sarkar, neta, saare” (They were all involved ... the police, the bureaucracy, the government, the politicians – all).